

THE MICHAEL THORNE SERIES - BOOK TWO

Shadows of the Past

A Psychological Crime Thriller

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READING SAMPLE

Formatted edition

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About this reading sample

This reading sample contains a continuous excerpt from the beginning of *Shadows of the Past*. It is based on the edition identified on the cover. The text below is drawn from the manuscript and is not the complete book.

Excerpt length: approximately 4,216 words.

PROLOGUE

THE NAME ON THE DOOR

* * *

Mara Ellison had lived under her name for thirty-seven years before the county informed her that it might belong to someone else.

The notice arrived on a Tuesday afternoon in an envelope too ordinary to fear.

Cook County seal in the upper-left corner.

Her address printed correctly.

No red lettering, no demand for payment, no threat that required action before midnight. The paper was heavier than a utility bill and lighter than a court summons. Official enough to be obeyed. Unremarkable enough to survive unopened beneath grocery advertisements for almost an hour.

Mara found it when she returned from work at the Berwyn rehabilitation centre.

She placed her keys in the blue ceramic bowl beside the door, removed her wet shoes and checked the window over the sink before turning on the kitchen light. The habit had no practical value. The alley behind the building contained two garbage containers, a fire escape and a brick wall painted with an advertisement that had outlived the company by twenty years.

She still checked.

Nothing moved outside.

Rain pressed a dark shine into the alley.

Mara opened the envelope with a butter knife.

The first line stopped her before the language became complicated.

NOTICE OF IDENTITY CONTINUITY REVIEW

She read it twice.

The phrase did not belong to ordinary government.

It belonged to rooms where adults lowered their voices before entering.

It belonged to forms she had been told never to sign.

It belonged to a man who had once explained that a name was safest when no one remembered the child who carried it first.

Mara sat at the kitchen table.

The notice stated that a routine digitisation project had identified a conflict between her birth record, a sealed juvenile file and a death registration issued in 1981. Her Social Security number remained valid. Her bank accounts were not restricted. No immediate action had been taken against her employment, tenancy or medical coverage.

The reassurance frightened her more than a threat would have.

It meant the writer knew which consequences she would calculate first.

A second page listed an appointment for 6:30 p.m. at the West Municipal Records Annex on South Homan Avenue.

Attendance was described as voluntary.

Failure to attend could result in referral to the State Identity Integrity Unit.

Mara had never heard of the unit.

The contact number connected to a recorded menu that used her full name before she entered any information.

She ended the call.

Beneath the notice lay a photograph.

Seventeen children stood in three rows beneath a painted sign.

ST. AGNES CHURCH SCHOOL — 1978

The image was not the blurred version shown on television during the Michael Thorne hearing.

This copy was sharp.

Mara could see the split seam in the second boy's collar. A scab on one girl's knee. The uneven cut of the paper bird drawn on Alice Crowley's wrist.

A black rectangle had been placed around the child at the far left of the first row.

A thin girl with straight hair and both hands hidden behind her back.

The name written beneath the rectangle was not Mara Ellison.

LEAH CORBIN

Mara turned the photograph over.

Three words had been written in blue ink.

YOU KEPT THIS ONE

She stood so quickly the chair struck the wall.

The apartment remained quiet.

Television from the unit below.

Water in the heating pipes.

A truck passing at the end of the alley.

No footsteps outside her door.

Mara took her phone from her coat pocket and searched the contacts she had not used in nine years.

The number under A.C. was disconnected.

She tried the second number.

A woman answered after five rings.

No greeting.

Mara said, "They used Leah."

The woman remained silent.

"The photograph came with a continuity notice."

"Did you touch it?"

"Yes."

"Anything else in the envelope?"

"An appointment."

"Do not go."

"I wasn't going to."

The woman breathed out.

Mara heard traffic around her. Not a room. Not a home.

"Leave the apartment," the woman said. "Take nothing you cannot replace."

"You told me the file was dead."

"I told you Adrian was dead."

"That is not the same."

"No."

"Who sent it?"

"I don't know."

Mara looked at the county seal.

"You know the language."

"Yes."

"Hale?"

A pause.

"Hale does not need to sign a letter to make it his."

Mara moved toward the bedroom.

"What do I take?"

"Medication. Cash. The red folder."

"The folder proves what they say."

"The folder proves what they did."

"Same paper."

"Different witness."

Mara opened the closet and removed a small travel bag from the upper shelf.

"Where do I go?"

"The laundromat on Oak Park Avenue. Use the rear entrance. I'll send someone."

"No police."

"I know."

"No federal task force."

"I know."

"And not Margaret."

The traffic sound disappeared from the other end.

"Mara—"

"Not Margaret."

"I heard you."

“That is not an answer.”

“It is the only one I can give before you move.”

The line ended.

Mara placed two bottles of medication in the bag, then opened the bottom drawer beneath her winter sweaters.

The red folder had faded toward brown.

Inside were three birth certificates.

Leah Corbin.

Mara Ellison.

A third name she had never used.

The first certificate recorded a birth in 1967.

The second recorded the same date, a different hospital and parents who did not exist.

The third had no child’s name at all.

Only a file number and the typed word:

CONTINUED

Mara put the folder into the bag.

She did not pack clothes.

She left the kitchen light on, took the rear stairs and crossed the alley beneath the fire escape.

The rain had strengthened.

At the corner, she looked back.

A man stood inside her kitchen.

Not near the door.

At the table.

He wore a grey county jacket and disposable gloves. The continuity notice lay in front of him.

Mara stepped behind the brick wall before he looked toward the window.

She did not call the woman again.

She did not call the police.

The laundromat stood four blocks away.

Its rear entrance opened beside a row of industrial dryers. Warm air carried detergent and damp fabric into the passage. A woman folding children's clothes glanced at Mara, then returned to matching socks.

Mara waited near the vending machines.

Six thirty passed.

No one approached her.

At 6:41, the lights over the rear half of the laundromat went out.

The dryers continued turning.

The attendant called toward the front counter.

Mara moved for the exit.

A man in a navy raincoat stepped through it.

He held no weapon.

He held a laminated county credential and the photograph from her kitchen table.

"Ms. Ellison," he said.

She backed away.

The woman folding clothes did not look up.

"You entered my home."

"No."

"I saw you."

"You saw a county employee."

“What are you?”

“Transportation.”

“For whom?”

He lowered the credential.

“For the name that survives review.”

Mara turned toward the front entrance.

The attendant had disappeared.

The woman at the folding table lifted a red sweater.

Beneath it lay a compact pistol pointed at Mara’s abdomen.

No one raised a voice.

No one needed to.

The man opened the rear door.

“Attendance remains voluntary,” he said.

Mara looked at the weapon.

“That word does not mean what you think it means.”

“It means the record will show you entered the vehicle without restraint.”

Outside, a white county transport van waited with its side door open.

Mara stepped into the rain.

The man did not touch her until she was inside.

Then he removed the travel bag from her shoulder and placed it between his feet.

The woman entered behind them.

The door closed.

No handcuffs.

No hood.

A camera above the windshield recorded Mara seated upright between two officials.

The van moved south.

The man opened the red folder.

He examined the three certificates in order.

Leah.

Mara.

Continued.

"You were told to destroy this," he said.

"I was eleven."

"You were fifty-two when Adrian contacted you."

Mara looked toward him.

He knew the year.

"What did he tell you?" the man asked.

"Nothing about you."

"That was not the question."

The woman removed a digital recorder from her coat and placed it on the metal shelf opposite Mara.

A red light appeared.

The man rested the three certificates side by side.

"We are not asking who you are," he said. "We are determining which name is allowed to survive."

Mara looked directly into the camera.

"My name is Mara Ellison."

The man drew a line through it.

CHAPTER 1

THE NAME REVIEW

* * *

Elena Martinez learned Mara Ellison was missing from a document that insisted she had arrived voluntarily.

The form lay inside a clear evidence sleeve on the passenger seat of Special Agent Desai's car.

At the top, beneath a Cook County seal, someone had typed:

IDENTITY CONTINUITY APPEARANCE RECORD

The lower half contained Mara's name, the West Municipal Records Annex address and a signature timed at 6:34 p.m.

Elena studied the handwriting while Desai drove west through morning traffic.

"Verified?" she asked.

"Her employer has six years of payroll forms. Same general hand. Not enough for a conclusion."

"Camera?"

"Municipal annex system shows her entering at six thirty-two."

"Does the annex exist?"

"The building does. The unit named in the notice does not."

"Who controls the footage?"

"County data services. We pulled a local copy before notifying the central administrator."

"Why before?"

"Because someone generated a valid appointment inside a retired records platform."

Elena looked through the windshield.

Grey morning pressed low over Cicero Avenue. Rainwater had dried in pale lines along the patched asphalt. A CTA train moved above the intersection, windows flashing between steel supports.

“How long has she been missing?”

“Her supervisor called at five twenty this morning. Ellison never arrived for the overnight medication audit.”

“Family?”

“None listed. One emergency contact disconnected nine years ago.”

“Why us?”

Desai glanced toward the document.

“Her apartment contained the St. Agnes photograph.”

The same class.

The same seventeen names.

The cassette from the fourth chair had been in federal evidence less than forty-eight hours.

Michael Thorne’s trial had not begun.

Judge Holt had extended the recess after the prosecution, defence and independent task force agreed that the recording could affect severance, admissibility and the history underlying Michael’s claimed mental-state evidence.

It did not change whether he killed Gabriel Shaw.

It changed how many adults had built the language he later used.

Elena had not listened to the tape with Michael.

That had been deliberate.

He heard his copy in a secured consultation room with Samuel Price. Elena heard hers beside Desai, Wells, an archivist and the court-appointed audio specialist. No one watched Michael's face while the child spoke. No one allowed his reaction to become the centre of Adrian Cole's account.

The precaution had not prevented every headline.

MICHAEL THORNE WAS NOT THE FIRST.

THE CHILD BEFORE THE CURATOR.

POLICE USED STOLEN IDENTITY IN SECRET PROGRAM.

Each statement contained enough truth to do damage.

Desai turned onto a residential street lined with narrow brick apartment buildings.

"Conflict review?" Elena asked.

"Approved at six ten. You are assigned to the Ellison disappearance only. You do not handle evidence offered against Thorne, interview him, or participate in charging decisions involving his existing case."

"And if the disappearance connects directly to him?"

"You step out."

"To whom?"

"Me."

"You already have three federal investigations."

"Four."

"That does not improve the answer."

"It is still the answer."

Desai parked behind an unmarked Internal Affairs vehicle.

David Wells stood beneath the building awning with a paper cup in his left hand and his right arm still supported by a dark brace. The injury from Ascension House had reduced his movement without improving his patience.

"You're late," he said.

Desai checked her watch.

"We are two minutes early."

"You're late to the part where the county denies sending the notice."

Elena looked at the apartment building.

"Who found the scene?"

"Landlord. We asked him to enter after her supervisor reported the absence and the work contact could not reach her."

"Signs of forced entry?"

"None at the door."

"That answer has another answer behind it."

Wells took a drink of coffee.

"Kitchen window was unlocked. Fire-escape moisture pattern suggests someone used it after the rain started."

"Footwear?"

"Partial. Smooth overshoe or disposable cover."

"Inside?"

"Come look."

The second-floor hallway smelled of boiled cabbage and wet carpet. A child's scooter rested beside one door. A handwritten notice about package theft had been taped beside the mailboxes.

Mara Ellison's apartment door stood open under an evidence seal.

A white paper placard had been fixed above the number with transparent tape.

LEAH CORBIN

Elena stopped before crossing the threshold.

"That was there when the landlord entered?"

Wells nodded.

"Photographed before removal from the door. We left it in place after the scene was secured."

"Public record on that name?"

"Juvenile birth registration, 1967. Death certificate, 1981. No confirmed body."

"One of the seventeen?"

"Yes."

"Ellison?"

"Current identity begins in 1989. Earlier records sealed."

Elena put on shoe covers and gloves.

The apartment did not look searched.

Cushions remained aligned on the sofa. A library book lay open beside a pair of reading glasses. Two framed photographs showed Mara with colleagues at a retirement party and beside an older man near Lake Michigan.

No childhood images.

The kitchen chair had struck the wall hard enough to leave a fresh mark.

On the table, investigators had placed numbered markers beside the opened envelope, the continuity notice and a colour copy of the St. Agnes photograph.

The child named Leah Corbin had been boxed in black.

Elena leaned closer without touching.

The girl's face contained nothing Elena could confidently match to the adult in the framed photographs.

Same narrow jaw, possibly.

Same distance between the eyes, possibly.

Age, weight, dental work and expectation could construct resemblance faster than evidence.

"Facial comparison?" she asked.

"Independent analysts have the original," Desai said. "No one was told which child to compare."

"Good."

Wells pointed toward the reverse-side photograph displayed on a separate evidence card.

YOU KEPT THIS ONE

"Handwriting?" Elena asked.

"Unknown."

"Meaning?"

"Also unknown."

"Then stop offering it with your face."

Wells' expression did not change.

"My face offered nothing."

"It offered a theory."

"What theory?"

"That she kept the name. Or kept evidence. Or survived when someone else did not."

"All plausible."

"Plausible is where these people worked."

Wells looked toward the placard above the door.

"Yes."

The red folder Mara had removed was not in the apartment.

They knew it existed because a rectangular absence remained in the dust beneath the sweaters in her bedroom drawer. The landlord's maintenance photograph from three months earlier showed the corner of a faded red cover.

The building's rear camera captured Mara leaving at 6:17 with a small travel bag.

No one followed her through the alley.

At 6:20, a man wearing a county jacket entered the same alley from the opposite direction.

His face remained hidden beneath the angle of the fire escape.

He left seven minutes later carrying nothing.

The kitchen camera did not exist.

No neighbour saw him enter.

The window showed no pry marks.

"He knew it would be unlocked," Elena said.

"Or she left it unlocked when she departed," Desai replied.

"During a storm?"

"People do irrational things under stress."

"That sentence has buried enough witnesses."

Desai accepted the correction.

"She may have been instructed to leave it open."

"By whom?"

"We recovered an eleven-minute call from a prepaid number at 5:58."

"Recording?"

"No. Cell-site places the caller near the Eisenhower Expressway."

"Voice identification?"

"None."

Elena examined the notice.

The language was precise without being clear.

Current benefits shall remain temporarily unaffected.

Appearance is voluntary unless subsequent review establishes statutory necessity.

Failure to preserve original identity materials may constitute obstruction of a protected records process.

Each sentence permitted reassurance and threat at the same time.

"Lasker," Elena said.

Wells looked at her.

"Because it sounds legal?"

"Because it postpones the moment when consent becomes compulsion."

"Edward Lasker is under monitored home release."

"Monitored by whom?"

"Federal pretrial services."

"Device active?"

"Yes."

“Continuous location?”

“House and medical visits.”

“That is not what I asked.”

Wells took out his phone.

“I’ll request the raw log.”

Desai moved toward the counter.

A blue ceramic bowl held Mara’s keys.

House key.

Mail key.

Work locker.

A fourth key smaller than the others, brass, with no label.

“Not on the initial inventory,” Desai said.

The evidence technician photographed it.

Elena did not pick it up.

“Old safe-deposit key?” Wells asked.

“Could be.”

“Church locker?”

“Could be.”

“Fourth-chair compartment?”

Elena looked at him.

He nodded once.

“Too soon.”

The technician bagged the key.

From the living room came a short electronic tone.

Everyone stopped.

The library book lay beside Mara’s reading glasses.

Beneath it, almost hidden by the cover, a phone screen had illuminated.

Not Mara's primary phone. That device last registered near the laundromat before going dark.

This one was older, without a case.

The screen displayed a calendar reminder.

IDENTITY REVIEW — 8:00 A.M.

Below it:

BRING THE ORIGINAL NAME.

Desai photographed the screen before touching the device.

"Airplane mode," she said. "No active service."

"Then the reminder was set earlier," Elena replied.

"Or remotely before service was disabled."

"Unlock?"

"Four digits."

Wells glanced toward the wall clock.

It read 7:58.

Elena looked back at the phone.

Two minutes.

"Do not guess 0217," she said.

"I wasn't going to."

"You thought it."

"So did you."

"That is why we do not use it."

At exactly eight, the phone played an audio file.

No one touched the screen.

A woman's voice entered the room.

Calm.

Older.

"You were told the name would protect you."

A pause.

"It protected the people who used it."

Another pause.

"If the notice has arrived, do not attend the appointment. Do not contact local police. Do not give the red folder to Margaret Beck Crowe."

Elena looked toward Desai.

The voice continued.

"Find Alice. Tell her Adrian kept the second list."

The file ended.

No dramatic click.

No hidden message.

Sixteen seconds.

"Voice?" Wells asked.

"Unknown," Desai said.

"Elena?"

She had heard Evelyn Thorne speak in interview rooms, hospitals and the chapel at Ascension House.

The rhythm was similar.

The age was similar.

Similarity was not identification.

"It could be Evelyn," she said. "It could be someone imitating a publicly available voice sample. We verify."

Wells called the protection unit assigned to Evelyn.

The response came quickly.

Evelyn was present.

Her attorney was with her.

No outgoing calls from the secured line.

Elena asked for a physical video check with a time-specific phrase and two officers visible in frame.

Three minutes later, Evelyn appeared on Desai's encrypted screen holding a newspaper and looking irritated.

"I did not record a message for Mara Ellison," she said.

"Do you know the name?" Elena asked.

"No."

"Leah Corbin?"

Evelyn's expression changed.

Not recognition of a person.

Recognition of a category.

"Where did you hear it?"

"St. Agnes list."

Evelyn looked toward someone outside the frame, likely her attorney.

"Leah was marked transfer complete."

"What does that mean?"

"I never knew."

"Who used the phrase?"

"Hale."

"Did Margaret Beck Crowe handle the transfer?"

"I saw her signature on later copies."

"Did you hear the audio file we sent?"

"Yes."

"Is it your voice?"

"No."

"Could it be an old recording?"

Evelyn listened again through the secured connection.

"No."

"Why?"

"The woman says 'original name' the way Crowne taught staff to say it after 1994. Before that they said 'source identity.'"

"Mara's reminder was created yesterday."

"I know."

"You are identifying terminology, not a person."

"Yes."

Evelyn looked directly at Elena through the screen.

"Do not bring Michael the recording."

"That decision is not yours."

"No."

"Why say it?"

"Because he will recognize the pauses."

"From whom?"

"His father."

The connection remained open.

No one in the apartment spoke.

Evelyn continued.

“James used silence before a false choice. Long enough for the other person to supply the missing threat.”

Elena replayed the message in her head.

You were told the name would protect you.

Pause.

It protected the people who used it.

Pause.

The listener completed the danger.

“Did James record training messages?” Elena asked.

“Yes.”

“For whom?”

“Officers. Informants. Sometimes children.”

“Could this be him?”

“No. The voice is a woman.”

“The structure.”

“Yes.”

“Who else learned it?”

Evelyn looked tired before she answered.

“Everyone who stayed.”

The video call ended at her attorney’s request.

Desai sealed the old phone inside a signal-blocking bag.

“We need the laundromat footage,” Elena said.

“Local detectives are preserving it.”

“No central upload.”

“Already instructed.”

“Traffic cameras between here and the annex.”

“In progress.”

“Raw pretrial-services location for Lasker.”

“Wells has it moving.”

“Margaret?”

“Last verified address abandoned six months ago.”

“Alice?”

“No protected identity confirmed.”

Elena looked at the St. Agnes photograph.

Seventeen children.

The case would encourage them to treat the row as a system before learning the people.

That was how the first theft began.

A list before a life.

“We start with Mara,” she said. “Workplace, neighbours, prescriptions, financial activity, the man in the lake photograph. We do not call her Leah unless evidence establishes she used that name.”

Wells nodded.

Desai’s phone vibrated.

She read the message.

“Municipal annex footage is ready.”

They viewed it on a laptop disconnected from the apartment network.

At 6:32 p.m., Mara entered the West Municipal Records Annex through the public entrance.

She carried no travel bag.

Her hair was dry.

Her coat was different.

Elena watched the image twice.

"That is not the woman from the alley camera."

"Facial match says eighty-seven percent," Desai said.

"Against which source?"

"Employment photograph."

"Posture?"

"Different."

"Height?"

"Within two centimetres."

The woman on-screen approached a reception desk.

No employee sat behind it.

She signed the appearance record, looked directly at the ceiling camera and entered a secured corridor using a temporary badge.

The time stamp read 6:34.

At 6:39, the corridor camera lost signal.

At 6:43, the real Mara was recorded at the laundromat four miles away.

The appearance form had been signed by someone wearing her face before the abduction team reached her.

Not digital fabrication alone.

A physical substitute.

Desai froze the frame as the woman turned.

A small scar marked the skin beneath her left ear.

Wells said, "Recognition?"

"No," Elena replied.

But she knew someone who might recognize the method.

That did not mean she wanted to ask him.

At 9:26, Samuel Price filed an emergency request for Michael Thorne to receive the continuity notice.

He did not request the video.

He did not request the photograph.

Only the wording of the notice.

The filing stated that Michael could identify language used in historical materials not yet indexed by the task force.

Elena read the request in Desai's car outside Mara's building.

"He knows the notice exists," she said.

"The photograph appeared in the sealed court supplement," Desai replied.

"The wording did not."

"Price may have learned it from the prosecution."

"Then we document who."

"We will."

"Do you support access?"

Desai looked toward the apartment window where the kitchen light still burned.

"Limited written extract. No victim address, no image, no investigative questions."

"He will answer the question he wants."

"Then we do not ask one."

The court approved a six-line excerpt at 10:11.

Michael received it through Price in a secured consultation room.

No investigator attended.

A fixed camera recorded the exchange.

Michael read the notice once.

He placed it square with the edge of the table.

His pocket watch remained in evidence. Without it, his left hand still moved toward the empty place inside his vest before stopping.

Price waited.

Michael read the second paragraph again.

Current benefits shall remain temporarily unaffected.

Appearance is voluntary unless subsequent review establishes statutory necessity.

He looked toward the camera.

Not at Price.

At whoever would later review the recording.

"The appointment is not where they took her," he said.

Price did not ask how he knew.

Michael continued.

"It is where they created the record showing she attended."

Price remained silent.

"The person who signed for her will have a mark beneath the left ear," Michael said.

Price's expression changed before he controlled it.

"You were not given footage."

"No."

"How do you know about the mark?"

Michael looked down at the notice.

"Because the substitute is not pretending to be Mara Ellison."

"Who is she pretending to be?"

"The woman Mara would have become if the first transfer had been completed."

"That is not a name."

"No."

"Do you know the name?"

Michael folded his hands.

"Yes."

Price waited.

Michael did not speak.

"You asked the court to see this," Price said.

"I asked to verify the language."

"A woman is missing."

"I know."

"Then give me the name."

Michael looked at the camera again.

"Elena has to ask."

Price leaned back.

"No."

Michael's eyes returned to him.

"No?"

"You do not get to build the meeting."

"Then she will lose time."

"That will be your choice, not hers."

For the first time, the page no longer sat perfectly aligned beneath Michael's hands.

One corner had shifted.

Price left it that way.

At 10:19, he carried Michael's statement out of the room.

The final line on the recording came after the door closed.

Michael spoke to the empty chair across from him.

"They are not abducting the children."

He looked down at the county seal.

"They are correcting the survivors."

Continue reading

You have reached the end of this reading sample from *Shadows of the Past*. The complete work continues beyond this excerpt.

The Michael Thorne Series - Book Two